

Brian Colfer

Staff Platform Engineer — CI/CD & Developer Productivity

San Francisco, CA

brian.colfer@gmail.com • linkedin.com/in/briancolfer

Summary

Staff Platform Engineer with 20+ years designing and evolving software delivery systems across companies including ServiceNow, Upstart, Apple, and eBay.

Specializes in improving how software is built, tested, and released by reshaping both technical systems and developer workflows. Focused on reducing delivery risk, accelerating feedback cycles, and enabling teams to ship reliably at scale.

Brings a systems-level perspective that connects infrastructure, developer experience, and organizational behavior.

Experience

CheloniSystems — Founder / Platform Engineer

October 2025 – Present

- Designed and launched [Behavior Insights](#), a production Ruby on Rails web application that enables users to track patterns across behaviors and outcomes
- Built and operate the full delivery system (CI/CD, deployment, persistence, monitoring), enabling rapid and low-risk iteration
- Defined product direction and data model, translating behavioral analysis concepts into practical user workflows
- Onboarded early users and iterated based on real usage patterns, prioritizing clarity and correctness
- Collaborate with and mentor two junior engineers contributing to application code, testing, deployment, and CI/CD workflows

ServiceNow — Build & Release Engineer

March 2023 – October 2025

- Initiated and led a 14-week effort to decompose a monolithic repository (80+ projects), coordinating across 12 globally distributed teams (~50 engineers) to enable independent ownership and improve release reliability by 40%
- Evaluated architectural tradeoffs between scaling CI/CD automation within a monolith vs. modularizing services; aligned leadership on prioritizing long-term maintainability over short-term automation gains
- Defined and enforced CI/CD standards across teams by establishing requirements, tracking progress, and distributing implementation work to ensure consistent adoption at scale
- Navigated resistance from multiple teams by building consensus and providing ongoing support, enabling successful migration without disrupting delivery
- Built automated merge request analysis and enforcement tooling, increasing development velocity by 60% while achieving over 90% test coverage
- Reduced environment setup time from weeks to days by standardizing repository configuration and pipeline patterns across the organization
- Shifted feedback cycles from multi-day delays to same-day validation by integrating testing, security scanning, and quality gates directly into pipelines

Upstart — DevOps Engineer

November 2020 – February 2023

- Reduced Jenkins startup time from 14 hours to 10 minutes by automating cleanup across 2,500 stale branches spanning 56 repositories

- Established shared CI/CD frameworks and automation patterns that reduced repository maintenance effort from months to minutes
- Introduced end-to-end delivery validation and quality gates, reducing production issues by 30%+ and increasing test coverage by 40%
- Enabled teams to adopt continuous delivery practices by embedding testing and deployment validation into daily workflows
- Standardized and enforced security scanning across CI/CD pipelines organization-wide, embedding automated quality gates that reduced manual compliance effort and prevented critical vulnerabilities from reaching production

Earlier Experience

- **Aktana — Senior Release Engineer** (April 2020 – October 2020)
- **Loanpal — Senior DevOps Engineer** (January 2020 – April 2020)
- **Subspace — DevOps Release Engineer / Site Reliability Engineer** (September 2019 – January 2020)
- **Zendesk — Release Engineer** (September 2016 – 2019)
- **Apple — Release Engineer, Build Improvement** (May 2014 – August 2016)
- **eBay Advertising — Senior Release Engineer** (March 2006 – May 2014)
- Led a project at Aktana to update Jenkins pipelines and initiated modernization of its Docker deployment mechanism
- Initiated modernization of the infrastructure as code supporting AWS Lambda deployments at Loanpal
- Joined Subspace as a DevOps Release Engineer and transitioned into an SRE role; modernized the Prometheus query interface, began automating Grafana dashboards in Python, and improved deployment processes using Ansible and Rundeck
- Migrated builds for 120 Zendesk projects to Google Cloud Build, reducing build time by 40%; implemented CloudBees CI/CD infrastructure supporting up to 100 engineers
- Reduced Apple iTunes Java build time by 30% by migrating from Ant to Maven and introduced semantic versioning for shared libraries
- Modernized build, deployment, version control, and test automation at eBay, supporting globally distributed engineering teams over eight years

Additional roles before 2006 include Vontu, Akamai, Kaiser Permanente, Topica, and Informix Software.

Education

MPA (Graduate coursework in Public Administration)

San Francisco State University

BA, English & Psychology

California Lutheran University

Skills

CI/CD & Delivery: Jenkins · CloudBees · GitLab CI/CD · GitHub Actions · Google Cloud Build · CircleCI · Argo CD · Spinnaker · Tekton · Rundeck · Kamal

Cloud, Containers & Infrastructure: AWS · Google Cloud Platform · Docker · Kubernetes · Helm · Terraform · Ansible

Artifacts, Quality & Security: JFrog Artifactory · JFrog Xray · Nexus · Harbor · SonarQube · JaCoCo

Languages & Frameworks: Ruby · Ruby on Rails · Python · Bash · Groovy · Java

Observability: Datadog · Grafana · Prometheus · ELK Stack

Practices: Platform Engineering · Developer Productivity · Continuous Delivery · Infrastructure as Code · Trunk-Based Development · Test Automation